

A.K. ANTONY

Defence

Mr Clean

In the labyrinthine corridors of South Block, A.K. Antony, 69, is referred to as Saint Antony, symbolic of his squeaky clean image. Yet, he also has the image of a ditherer, and major modernisation projects for the armed forces have been hanging fire. In his second avatar, he has declared a war on corruption, warning that deals would be "ruthlessly cancelled" if malpractices were found in acquisition, but what is required is quick decision-making, alien to his low-key style.

Priorities

- Push for the long-delayed modernisation of armed forces with 155 mm howitzers, fighter aircraft and submarines.
- Re-equip the forces with hi-tech equipment to fight low-intensity conflicts.
- Push for policy reforms to bring in the private sector and increase accountability of defence PSUs.
- Lay down a time-bound long-term plan to gradually reduce and finally end dependence on foreign arms imports.

Is he the one? Bofors torpedoed the Congress and Antony, as spotless as they come, was brought in to ensure that history does not repeat itself. It hasn't, so far, and ensured him membership of the charmed inner circle but anti-corruption alone is not enough. With the entire neighbourhood in turmoil and India facing multiple security threats, he is perhaps not suited for the times.

Personal Quirks

Believes what is good for him is good for the country.

▼ 40%



KASIF



RAVI S SAHANI

SHARAD PAWAR

Agriculture, Food and Public Distribution

Agro Power

Thirty-one years ago, he led a rag-tag coalition to become Maharashtra's youngest-ever chief minister. In the past three decades, Sharad Pawar has carved a niche for himself as a development politician. From farmers at Pune's Mandai or bankers on Dalal Street, Pawar understands them all. Between 2004 and 2009, Pawar shrugged off criticism over his interest in cricket and pushed a new deal for farmers. He ramped up availability of credit, expanded extension and advisory services, made better seeds available and hiked procurement prices to deliver three years of record output.

Priorities

- Invest in irrigation projects to harness every drop of water and enable better crop channels.
- Enable wider credit availability for farmers through conventional and non-conventional methods.
- Create incentives to speed up research in high-yield short-duration crop varieties.
- Improve market infrastructure so that farmers can store and sell at will and get better prices.

Is he the one? Without doubt he is the best man for the job. His comprehension of the factors that impact input and output in agriculture, his understanding of modern market-driven pricing mechanisms and passion make him the ideal candidate for the restructuring of India's agriculture sector.

Style Statement

White half-sleeved shirts and trousers in Mumbai and Delhi. Deep blue bandgala for overseas trips.

▼ 70%